Detailing Deaths Behind Bars Extension:

2015-2025

The Texas Justice Initiative (TJI) is a nonprofit organization that collects, analyzes, publishes and provides oversight for criminal justice data throughout Texas. This report outlines the progress of our work, funded by Arnold Ventures, to document and analyze the circumstances under which people are dying in custody of Texas prisons and jails.

I. Introduction

This report expands TJI's work on jail and prison custodial death reports, looking at not only the quantifiable data fields, which are populated by preset options or short answer fill-in-the-blank entries, but also the text summaries, which are open-ended descriptions of deaths. Based on an inquiry among peers, this analysis by TJI is the first of its kind to review details from official text summaries from custodial death reports pertaining to the deaths of people behind bars. Some similar research is being conducted on media narratives of police killings, as well as coding open-ended text in autopsy reports.

A couple of terms to know that pertain to this work:

Multiple choice "data fields": Each month, Texas Justice Initiative (TJI) files requests under the Texas Public Information Act for a spreadsheet of data from custodial death reports submitted to the state.This data, provided by the Texas Attorney General's office, gives us some insight into custodial deaths, including the total number of deaths per year since 2005, demographics of decedents, the type of custody decedents were held in, the type of location where they died, and causes of deaths.

Open-ended "text summary" field: At the end of Texas' custodial death reports is an open-ended text summary field, in which entries range from concise to verbose. Texas AG's office has taken the position that these summaries are not publicly releasable without redactions, though the original reports — containing complete summaries — are accessible and downloadable on a website operated by the Texas AG's office. Collecting the reports is a time-consuming, cumbersome and manual process that involves downloading thousands of summaries and adding the text into our database.

The Arnold Ventures grant allowed TJI to collect and parse the text summaries to look for patterns, differences from the other data fields, and trends that might lead to better outcomes and further areas of exploration.

II. Data Summary

Our previous report, (Deaths Behind Bars 2020-2024), examined the last four years of data. Initially, summaries were not found to be particularly useful, and that remains true for reports on deaths in custody that took place in Texas prisons. However, a more exhaustive analysis of reports from 2015 to 2025 found that most summaries in reports of deaths inTexas jails are insightful when it comes to the

agency or person identified as being responsible for the death. And perhaps more importantly, the summaries provide a clearer picture of the manner of death for reports on jail deaths — and sometimes a conflicting picture — from the report's other data fields.

The analysis below details the critical inconsistencies that the text summaries illuminated within custodial death reports from Texas prisons and jails.

Report Data vs. Text Summaries: Data Misalignment Issues

In the 9,000-plus reports that we analyzed, systematic inconsistencies emerged between information reported in the data fields and the death summaries within the same reports. Here a few examples:

- **Justifiable homicides:** We found that individuals who died from injuries sustained before they were in the custody of a county jail are incorrectly identified as " justifiable homicides in jail." In these cases, incarcerated individuals died in hospitals or had been hospitalized, released, and later died in jails from injuries sustained by an officer's deadly use of force, according to the text summaries. There were many cases where the responsible agency was classified as "other," but the text summaries pointed to the death actually occurring in a county jail or state prison facility.
- **Manner of death inconsistencies:** We found that:
    - Approximately 25% of death reports analyzed contain descriptions of deaths in the text summaries that are inconsistent with the listed manner of death in the same reports. For example, the data fields show that there were 486 deaths by suicide in Texas prisons over the past 10 years, but the summaries revealed another six.
    - Furthermore, a number of text summaries of deaths by suicide described accidental deaths or deaths by natural causes, while data fields list them as "undetermined" or "autopsy pending."

These discrepancies raise important questions about:

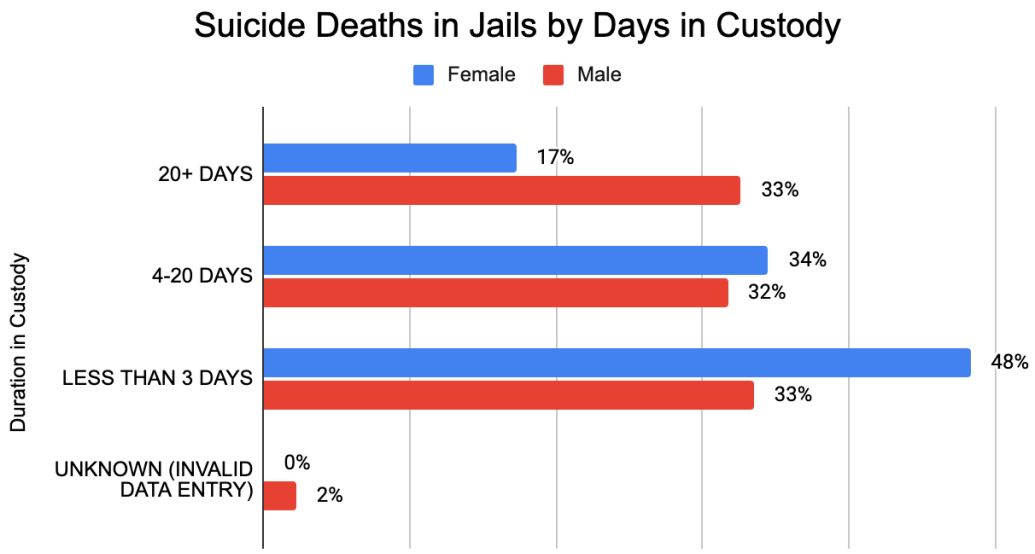
- Data integrity and reporting standards across correctional facilities
- Consistency in death investigation protocols
- Transparency in custody death reporting
- The reliability of summary-level data for policy and oversight purposes

Analysis of Text Summaries - Jails

From 2015 to 2025, approximately 1,300 people died in Texas jails. Deaths are categorized as natural, accidental (including overdose), suicide, and homicide (including justifiable homicides). Here a few highlights TJI noticed:

- Homicides in jails are low. Fourteen jail inmates were killed by other inmates, based on information in text summaries. Most fatal injuries were blunt force head trauma without use of weapons. In one death, the decedent was found with a plastic bag over his head, placed there by other inmates. In more than one death, the individual had been deemed physically okay after an altercation, only to pass away later.
- Suicides may be undercounted. Twenty-five women and 228 men died by suicide. However, suicides may be undercounted, due to intentional overdoses not being counted as suicide. We suspect this undercount because some suicides and overdoses occur soon after an individual is booked into jail.
- Even if undercounted, the deadliest years for suicides have been recent: 2020, 2022, and 2024 each saw at least 30 individuals die by suicide. The deadliest year for women was 2020, while for men, suicides in jails have risen over time, with the deadliest year in 2024 with 30 deaths.
- One of the most alarming patterns is that most suicides of women occur in within the first 24 hours of booking. Of the women who died by suicide in jail, 82% died within the first week of being booked in jail, with nearly half dying within their first 3 days in jail. Of the men who died by suicide in jail, 32% die within the first 20 days of being incarcerated, and 35% die within 24 hours of being booked. See chart below. Of

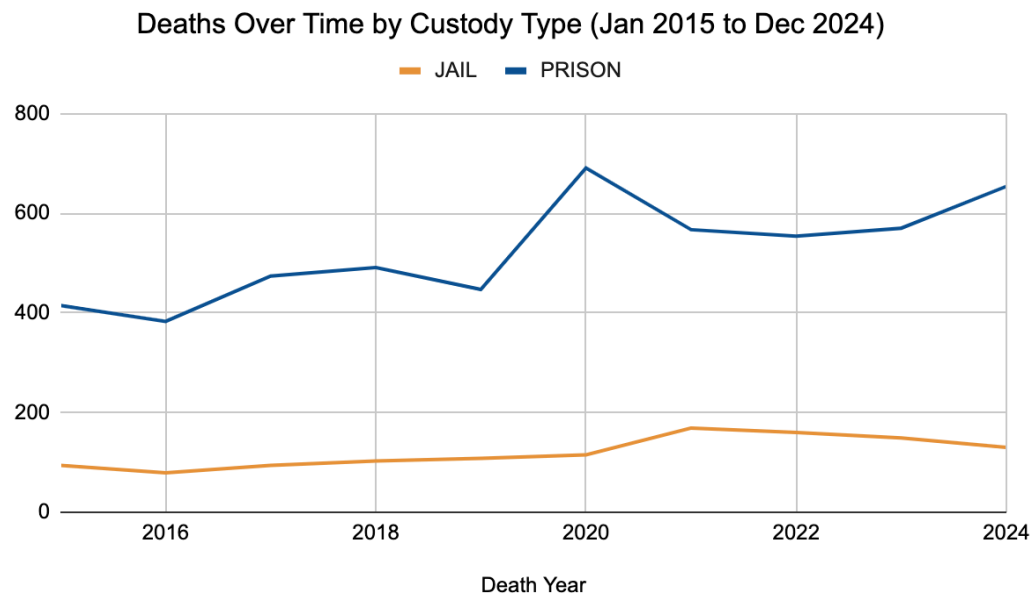
the women who died by suicide in jail, nearly half died within their first 72 hours after being booked in jail. Of the men who died by suicide in jail, 33% passed away within the first 72 hours.



- According to the text summaries, the majority of men who died by suicide were alone in single cells. A small number died in a multiple person or detox cell, but were still alone.
- By far, the most common method of suicide is hanging, the predominant method (90%) of men. All but one woman who died by suicide died by hanging.
- Mental health problems contribute to jail suicides: . 36% of women and 20% of men who died by suicide in jail were documented to have mental health problems.
- Mental health problems and medical problems (as noted in data fields) were found to be statistically significant. Statisically, if an individual presents with medical or mental health problems, their chances of dying by suicide are higher than those who do not.

Analysis of Texas Summaries - Prisons

Texas' prison population has decreased over the last decade, from 156,000 in 2015 to 136,000 in 2025. And yet, the number of deaths in custody has risen. The highest number of deaths in prison occurred in 2020, presumably from COVID-19. However, prison deaths have not returned to pre-pandemic numbers and appear to be trending upward. Meanwhile, deaths in county jails have remained mostly flat.

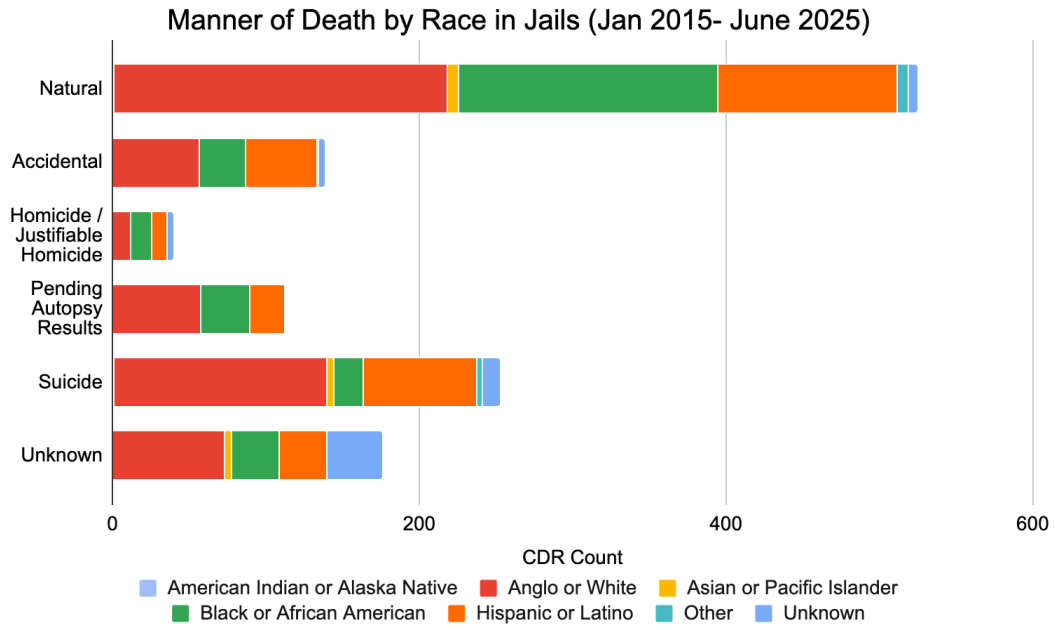


- Twenty-two women and 470 men died by suicide in Texas prisons. Again, these numbers may be an undercount, due to overdoses, which are categorized as overdoses

Analysis of Race and Manner of Death in Jails and Prisons

Regarding race, our findings from deaths in the past 10 years are almost identical to trends found in our first report on deaths from 2020 through 2024.

- The Black population is over-represented, particularly in natural deaths in both prisons and jails, when considering the overall demographic breakdown of prison and jail populations.
- White and Latino individuals are more likely to die by suicide in both prisons and jails than Black individuals in prisons and jails.



III. Next Steps

What good is the information on a death in custody report if the report itself is inconsistent and contradictory? Carceral entities in Texas, particularly county jails, would be wise to evaluate their custodial death reports and determine how they could be improved upon. In particular, reports would be more insightful and perhaps help yield better outcomes if the data fields and text summaries were aligned and portrayed an accurate and fully representative account of a death in custody.

The Texas AG's office, which collects custodial death reports, should:

- Establish standardized reporting protocols for custody deaths,
- Implement quality assurance measures for data consistency, and
- Develop clear guidelines for responsibility determination in custody death cases.

Reporters and researchers should utilize TJI's website to dig deeper in the text summaries for future work. And, 2TJI will continue to review the reports and update our users on any findings.

IV. Acknowledgments

Our experienced team comprises Eva Ruth Moravec, a journalist and TJI's founding executive director; Elaine Ayo, a data and software engineer; Kaitlyn Wallace, business data analyst, and Bergan Casey, communications specialist. Special thanks to Dr. Jiletta Kubena, a criminologist who, along with her senior students at Our Lady of the Lake University in San Antonio, completed the analysis.

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